

Colonel William M. Wadley as supervisor “of all railroads in the Confederate States.”

Until late 1863, Wadley and his successor Frederick W. Sims managed impressively, despite a chronic lack of raw materials or factories, to repair lines and equipment. In July 1861, General Joseph E. Johnston moved an army in the Shenandoah Valley by rail to arrive just in time for the First Battle of Bull Run. In the spring of 1862, railroads in Mississippi, Louisiana, and Alabama allowed General Albert S. Johnston to assemble his army before the Battle of Shiloh. In July 1862, more than 30,000 men under General Braxton Bragg were dispatched by rail from Mississippi to Chattanooga in under two weeks. This speedy transfer allowed Bragg to launch his invasion of Kentucky in the fall that year.

A year later, many key railheads had fallen to the Union. In 1864, even more were seized, including the critical junction at Atlanta. This effectively crippled the South’s ability to use its railroads and gave the Union armies more opportunities to redeploy troops for decisive victories.

21,276 The miles of railroad track (34,240km) in the Union states at the start of the war in 1861, compared with the Confederate states’ 9,000 miles (14,500km).